4. To arrange visits to foreign countries with a view to develop contacts with members of other parliaments.

FUNCTIONS OF THE IPG

The various functions performed and activities undertaken by the IPG are as follows:

1. The IPG acts as a link between the Parliament of India and the various parliaments of the world. This link is maintained through the exchange of delegations, goodwill missions, correspondence, documents, etc. with foreign parliaments.

2. The IPG functions as the (a) National Group of the IPU and (b) main branch of the CPA in India.

3. Addresses to the members of the Parliament by visiting Heads of State and Government of foreign countries and talks by eminent persons are arranged under the auspices of the IPG.

4. Seminars and symposia on parliamentary subjects of topical interest are organised periodically at national as well as international level.

5. Members of the IPG, when visiting abroad, are given letters of introduction to the Secretaries of the National Groups of the IPU and Secretaries of the CPA branches. The Indian Missions in the countries of visit are also suitably informed so as to enable them to get assistance and usual courtesies.

6. Only those members of the Parliament who are members of the IPG of at least six months' standing at the time of the composition of the delegation, may be included in the Indian Parliamentary delegations to foreign countries.

7. An uninterrupted flow of information to members regarding the activities of the IPG is maintained through the IPG Newsletter brought out every quarter. It is sent regularly to all members of the IPG, including associate members.

8. As per the decision of the IPG, an award of Outstanding Parliamentarian was instituted in the year 1995 to be given annually. A committee of five persons, constituted by the Speaker of the Lok Sabha, invites and finalises the nomination for the award.

PARLIAMENTARY FRIENDSHIP GROUPS

To encourage bilateral relations, the IPG constitutes Parliamentary Friendship Groups (PFGs) with other countries, in the Indian Parliament.

Each PFG consists of sitting members of Parliament (both from the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha). The Speaker of the Lok Sabha appoints the President of each PFG.

The management and control of all affairs of the PFGs vests in the IPG. The meetings of the PFGs are arranged on the sidelines of visiting Foreign Parliamentary Friendship Groups/Committees/Delegations. These meetings are held within the Parliament House complex.

The aims and objectives of the PFGs are mentioned below:

1. To maintain political, economic, social and cultural contact between the two countries.